



who burn carbon want forests and grasslands to be there to soak it up, we need to make it more profitable to preserve than to destroy them. Peat got headlines in *The Economist*, surely a first. And mangrove forests, nature's great gift to tropical coastlines, after a century of being destroyed for almost any reason, were suddenly being hailed as the great new solution to the great new problem of tucking carbon away where it can't do harm. They also protect coastal communities from storm surges, make drainage systems functional in cities, and create nurseries for fisheries but what may save them, ironically, is the desperate need of hyperconsumers for a way to deal with their carbon wastes.

But as the world slouched, grumpily, towards Copenhagen, the best new ideas of the global green movement were still at the margins of the negotiating agenda. Greens in rich countries in the North embraced one narrative about climate change—call it the Kyoto narrative—while most of those in the South embraced the same science, but used it to drive a fundamentally incompatible politics in the ostensibly incompatible name of climate justice. Both sides seemed convinced that dealing with climate change meant an exercise in shared, or disputed, sacrifice in spite of the fact that both had nobly and heroically stood up against the 20th century industrial behemoth.

2007 Al Gore and the United Nations Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) win the Nobel Peace Prize.

2008 The Indian Government releases a National Action Plan on Climate Change on June 30. Eight national missions including enhanced energy efficiency and sustainable agriculture, form the core of this plan.

SPIN-OFFS

Natural Effects

An Inconvenient Truth

Al Gore's documentary on climate change that picked up two Oscars in 2007.



The 11th Hour In 2007, Hollywood star Leonardo DiCaprio produced and narrated this full length documentary that examines the state of the global environment.

The Age of Stupid The movie stars Oscar nominee Pete Postlethwaite as a man in the devastated world of 2055, looking back at archive footage from 2007, wondering why we didn't stop climate change when we could.

Earth Matters Mike Pandey's weekly half-hour series on environment has been running on Doordarshan for the past 11 years.

THE GREAT WEAKNESS OF today's system is that it favours the industry instead of the environment.

JAIRAM RAMESH
ENVIRONMENT
MINISTER

Both were appalled by what mining and burning coal and oil was inflicting on the world; both understood that decentralised, renewable energy solutions would be enormously empowering to the world's poorest villagers; both should have united to make the obvious point: that hundreds of billions of dollars are flowing from industrial nations to the developing world for new energy production, and these investments are in fact substantially responsible for keeping poor countries still dependent on fossil fuels. It is the World Bank, not energy markets, that is funding new coal-fired power plants in India, while it starves new renewable technologies. Yet in Copenhagen, there will be no central, core thrust from this movement. Greens are still operating as if the important distinctions were national and regional—a Marxist would assert that they are still the victims of false consciousness.

This is, of course, bad for the environmental movement. But it is worse for the world's future, because we still need a new economic model to replace 20th century industrialism, a model that at least attempts to cope with the numeric realities of billions of new consumers, exhausted natural ecosystems and unstable climate. And that model must offer solutions and deliver opportunity. Targets and timetables, differentiated responsibilities are all well and good but what the world wants is a way to make a living without stealing from our children, to get to work without causing floods half a world away. Greens have not prevented diplomats and bureaucrats from draining the meaning and the hope out of Copenhagen—that's our biggest failure.

Having offered a harsh critique, it's important to stop and realise that only a decade ago environmental organisations, at least those in the North, were embarked on a very different journey as incrementalist watchdogs of the industrial future which was assumed to be much like the industrial past. Ten years is a long time in many ways but not for a new vision and a new future to emerge. Copenhagen is likely to be a grim disappointment. Such disappointments can be emerging teaching moments. Let's hope this one is.

Carl Pope is the Executive Director of the Sierra Club, one of America's most influential environmental organisations.

